THE AMERICAS AT WAR



An easy victory
On April 25, 1898, the American Asiatic squadron under Admiral Dewey destroyed the Spanish squadron in Manila Bay, without losing a single man during the battle. Here Dewey delivers the order "You may fire when ready, Gridley," from the bridge of his flagship *Olympia*.

FROM A BROAD PERSPECTIVE of world naval history, the 19th century in the Americas is important as the period when the United States began its emergence as a major naval power. This development was slow to occur, however. Until the last decade of the century, naval operations in the Americas were on a relatively modest scale, whether involving the United States or not. Naval power played a significant role in the American Civil War of 1861 to 1865, and that conflict provided a test-bed for new technologies such as iron armor and turret guns. Yet naval encounters never involved more than a handful of ships. Some intriguing naval battles were also fought in the seas and rivers of Southern America. But it was the creation of the "New Navy" of the United States from the 1880s that was to give the continent its first world-class fleet.

LIMITED FORCE

For much of the 19th century Americans simply saw no need for substantial naval forces. The United States was not seriously threatened by external enemies and Britain's dominant Royal Navy saw to it that the seas were safe for merchant shipping. The United States did make a gesture toward the imperialist use of naval power with the dispatch of a squadron under Commodore Matthew Perry to intimidate Japan in 1854, but Perry's four paddle steamers would not have impressed even one of the lesser European powers. At the outbreak of the Civil War in 1861 the US Navy comprised some 90 vessels, mostly of indifferent quality and condition. The conflict was the occasion for improvisation on both sides, the South showing particular ingenuity and boldness in taking on a naval struggle for which it could hardly have been worse prepared. The Union government converted a host of steam merchantmen to naval use and instituted a blockade of Southern ports.

Fighting far from home
The successful Confederate raider *Alabama* met her end on June 19, 1864, off Cherbourg, France, when she was tracked down by the USS *Kearsarge*. French and English spectators watched the uneven contest between the Confederate wooden cruiser and her armored foe.

Percussion caps
Loading a round into a handgun in the Civil War era still required a separate cartridge, ball, and percussion cap.

